Lesson 40

The Tribulation

(Adapted from the Foundations of Pentecostal Theology)

Aim: To teach the believers the biblical teaching of the Tribulation.

A. The Word "Tribulation" in Scripture.

In the Bible, the word "tribulation" is used in at least three different ways:

1. To apply to the trials and persecutions that the Christian believers will suffer throughout the Church age as a result of their identification with Christ: *"In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be a good cheer; I have overcome the world" (Jn. 16:33)*

33"I have told you these things, so that in me you may have peace. In this world you will have trouble. But take heart! I have overcome the world."

John, in his first epistle, explains why we suffer with Christ in this world: *"Therefore the world knoweth us not, because it*

knew Him not" (Jn. 3:1b). (See also 1Cor. 3:4; 2Thes. 1:4; Acts 14:22, Rom 12:12; Eph. 3:13; 2 Cor. 7:4)

John 3:1, Now there was a Pharisee, a man named Nicodemus who was a member of the Jewish ruling council.

1Cor. 3:4, For when one says, "I follow Paul," and another, "I follow Apollos" are you not mere human beings?

2Thes. 1:4, Therefore, among God's churches we boast about your perseverance and faith in all the persecutions and trials you are enduring.

Acts 14:22, strengthening the disciples and encouraging them to remain true to the faith. "We must go through many hardships to enter the kingdom of God," they said.

Romans 12:12,Be joyful in hope, patient in affliction, faithful in prayer.

Eph. 3:13, I ask you, therefore, not to be discouraged because of my sufferings for you, which are your glory.

2 Cor. 7:4, I have spoken to you with great frankness; I take great pride in you. I am greatly encouraged; in all our troubles my joy knows no bounds.

2. To apply to a special period of tribulation for Israel prophesied by Daniel (9:24-27). Jeremiah also makes reference to the same period calling it "Jacob's trouble" (Jer 30:7-9). Jesus describes the Great Tribulation (Mt. 24:21) and

confirms its application to Israel by the use of terms such as “Judea,” “the Sabbath day,” and “the abomination of desolation”) Dn 9:27) which refers to the desecration of the altar of the Jewish Temple by the Anti-Christ.

Daniel 9:24-27 24“Seventy ‘sevens’[a] are decreed for your people and your holy city to finish[b] transgression, to put an end to sin, to atone for wickedness, to bring in everlasting righteousness, to seal up vision and prophecy and to anoint the Most Holy Place.[c] 25 “Know and understand this: From the time the word goes out to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until the Anointed One,[d] the ruler, comes, there will be seven ‘sevens,’ and sixty-two ‘sevens.’ It will be rebuilt with streets and a trench, but in times of trouble. 26 After the sixty-two ‘sevens,’ the Anointed One will be put to death and will have nothing.[e] The people of the ruler who will come will destroy the city and the sanctuary. The end will come like a flood: War will continue until the end, and desolations have been decreed. 27 He will confirm a covenant with many for one ‘seven.’[f] In the middle of the ‘seven’[g] he will put an end to sacrifice and offering. And at the temple[h] he will set up an abomination that causes desolation, until the end that is decreed is poured out on him. Jeremiah 30:7-9,How awful that day will be! No other will be like it. It will be a time of trouble for Jacob, but he will be saved out of it. 8 “‘In that

day,' declares the LORD Almighty, 'I will break the yoke off their necks and will tear off their bonds; no longer will foreigners enslave them. 9 Instead, they will serve the LORD their God and David their king, whom I will raise up for them.

Matthew 24:21 21For then there will be great distress, unequaled from the beginning of the world until now—and never to be equaled again.

3. To apply to God's final wrath upon the Antichrist and the Gentile nations that follow him (Rv. 6:12-17), called the "Great Day of His Wrath."

It is very important that the three different applications of the word "tribulation" be clearly distinguished. The fact that believers must be ready to suffer trials and tribulations throughout the Church age (Acts 14:14) does not mean that the Church must go through the "Great Tribulation" and the final hour of "God's Wrath." God has promised to keep the church saints from (Gr.,ek, "out of") the tribulation period (Rv. 3:10; 1Thes. 5:9).

Furthermore, the "Great Tribulation," which is Daniel's "seventieth week" of the seventy week period determined for dealing with Israel (Dn. 9:24 27; 12:8-13), is not a part of the Church age; when the "fullness of the Gentiles" comes, as Paul explains in Romans 11:25, the Church will be raptured,

and God will turn again to effect the salvation of national Israel (Rom 11:24, 26; Rv. 7:4-8; Rv. 11, 12).

Revelation 6:12-17 12I watched as he opened the sixth seal. There was a great earthquake. The sun turned black like sackcloth made of goat hair, the whole moon turned blood red, 13 and the stars in the sky fell to earth, as figs drop from a fig tree when shaken by a strong wind.14The heavens receded like a scroll being rolled up, and every mountain and island was removed from its place. 15 Then the kings of the earth, the princes, the generals, the rich, the mighty, and everyone else, both slave and free, hid in caves and among the rocks of the mountains. 16 They called to the mountains and the rocks, "Fall on us and hide us[a] from the face of him who sits on the throne and from the wrath of the Lamb! 17 For the great day of their[b] wrath has come, and who can withstand it?"

Acts 14:14 14But when the apostles Barnabas and Paul heard of this, they tore their clothes and rushed out into the crowd, shouting:

Revelation 3:10 10Since you have kept my command to endure patiently, I will also keep you from the hour of trial that is going to come on the whole world to test the inhabitants of the earth.

1 Thessalonians. 5:9 9For God did not appoint us to suffer wrath but to receive salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.

Daniel 12:8-13 8I heard, but I did not understand. So I asked, "My lord, what will the outcome of all this be?" 9 He replied, "Go your way, Daniel, because the words are rolled up and sealed until the time of the end. 10 Many will be purified, made spotless and refined, but the wicked will continue to be wicked. None of the wicked will understand, but those who are wise will understand. 11 "From the time that the daily sacrifice is abolished and the abomination that causes desolation is set up, there will be 1,290 days. 12 Blessed is the one who waits for and reaches the end of the 1,335 days. 13 "As for you, go your way till the end. You will rest, and then at the end of the days you will rise to receive your allotted inheritance."

B. Daniel's Dream and Vision.

Daniel also prophesied about times of world domination by Gentile nations (Nebuchadnezzar's Image– Dn 2:31-44; Daniel's dream of four beasts– Dn 7:1-14).

The four parts of the image and the four beasts represented four successive Gentile empires, the last of which was to be the Roman Empire. According the dream of the

image, the Roman Empire would be revived in the form of ten kingdoms, represented by the ten toes of the image. According to the vision of the four beasts, the fourth would have ten horns from which a “little horn,” symbolizing the Antichrist, would come forth. In both the dream and the vision, the Son of Man will come in the time of the fourth empire to punish the nations and to set up His everlasting kingdom (Dn 2:31-35; 7:8-14; 12:1-3). In Matthew chapter twenty-four, and in Luke chapter twenty one, Jesus makes clear that the Great Tribulation will include Daniel’s seventieth week of God’s dealing with Israel and His final wrath against Satan and the wicked Gentile nations that serve him. (See also Zec. 14:1-4; Rv 14:20, 16:14-16, 19:19)

Daniel 2:31-44,31 “Your Majesty looked, and there before you stood a large statue—an enormous, dazzling statue, awesome in appearance. 32 The head of the statue was made of pure gold, its chest and arms of silver, its belly and thighs of bronze, 33 its legs of iron, its feet partly of iron and partly of baked clay. 34 While you were watching, a rock was cut out, but not by human hands. It struck the statue on its feet of iron and clay and smashed them. 35 Then the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver and the gold were all broken to pieces and became like chaff on a threshing floor in the summer. The wind swept them away without leaving a trace. But the rock

that struck the statue became a huge mountain and filled the whole earth.36“This was the dream, and now we will interpret it to the king.37Your Majesty, you are the king of kings. The God of heaven has given you dominion and power and might and glory; 38 in your hands he has placed all mankind and the beasts of the field and the birds in the sky. Wherever they live, he has made you ruler over them all. You are that head of gold. 39“After you, another kingdom will arise, inferior to yours. Next, a third kingdom, one of bronze, will rule over the whole earth.40Finally, there will be a fourth kingdom, strong as iron—for iron breaks and smashes everything—and as iron breaks things to pieces, so it will crush and break all the others. 41 Just as you saw that the feet and toes were partly of baked clay and partly of iron, so this will be a divided kingdom; yet it will have some of the strength of iron in it, even as you saw iron mixed with clay. 42As the toes were partly iron and partly clay, so this kingdom will be partly strong and partly brittle. 43 And just as you saw the iron mixed with baked clay, so the people will be a mixture and will not remain united, any more than iron mixes with clay.44 “In the time of those kings, the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that will never be destroyed, nor will it be left to another people. It will crush all those kingdoms and bring them to an end, but it will itself endure forever.

Daniel 7:1-14, In the first year of Belshazzar king of Babylon, Daniel had a dream, and visions passed through his mind as he was lying in bed. He wrote down the substance of his dream.2 Daniel said: “In my vision at night I looked, and there before me were the four winds of heaven churning up the great sea. 3 Four great beasts, each different from the others, came up out of the sea.4 “The first was like a lion, and it had the wings of an eagle. I watched until its wings were torn off and it was lifted from the ground so that it stood on two feet like a human being, and the mind of a human was given to it. 5 “And there before me was a second beast, which looked like a bear. It was raised up on one of its sides, and it had three ribs in its mouth between its teeth. It was told, ‘Get up and eat your fill of flesh!’6 “After that, I looked, and there before me was another beast, one that looked like a leopard. And on its back it had four wings like those of a bird. This beast had four heads, and it was given authority to rule. 7 “After that, in my vision at night I looked, and there before me was a fourth beast—terrifying and frightening and very powerful. It had large iron teeth; it crushed and devoured its victims and trampled underfoot whatever was left. It was different from all the former beasts, and it had ten horns. 8 “While I was thinking about the horns, there before me was another horn, a little one, which came up among them; and

three of the first horns were uprooted before it. This horn had eyes like the eyes of a human being and a mouth that spoke boastfully.9 “As I looked, “thrones were set in place, and the Ancient of Days took his seat. His clothing was as white as snow; the hair of his head was white like wool. His throne was flaming with fire, and its wheels were all ablaze. 10 A river of fire was flowing, coming out from before him. Thousands upon thousands attended him; ten thousand times ten thousand stood before him. The court was seated, and the books were opened. 11 “Then I continued to watch because of the boastful words the horn was speaking. I kept looking until the beast was slain and its body destroyed and thrown into the blazing fire. 12 (The other beasts had been stripped of their authority, but were allowed to live for a period of time.) 13 “In my vision at night I looked, and there before me was one like a son of man,[a] coming with the clouds of heaven. He approached the Ancient of Days and was led into his presence. 14 He was given authority, glory and sovereign power; all nations and peoples of every language worshiped him. His dominion is an everlasting dominion that will not pass away, and his kingdom is one that will never be destroyed.

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Daniel 12:1-3,“At that time Michael, the great prince who protects your people, will arise. There will be a time of distress such as has not happened from the beginning of nations until then. But at that time your people—everyone whose name is found written in the book—will be delivered. 2 Multitudes who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake: some to everlasting life, others to shame and everlasting contempt. 3 Those who are wise[a] will shine like the brightness of the heavens, andthose who lead many to righteousness, like the stars for ever and ever.

Zec 14:1-4,A day of the LORD is coming, Jerusalem, when your possessions will be plundered and divided up within your very walls. 2 I will gather all the nations to Jerusalem to fight

against it; the city will be captured, the houses ransacked, and the women raped. Half of the city will go into exile, but the rest of the people will not be taken from the city. 3 Then the LORD will go out and fight against those nations, as he fights on a day of battle. 4 On that day his feet will stand on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem, and the Mount of Olives will be split in two from east to west, forming a great valley, with half of the mountain moving north and half moving south.

Revelation 14:20,They were trampled in the winepress outside the city, and blood flowed out of the press, rising as high as the horses' bridles for a distance of 1,600 stadia.

Revelation 16:14-16, 14 They are demonic spirits that perform signs, and they go out to the kings of the whole world, to gather them for the battle on the great day of God Almighty. 15 "Look, I come like a thief! Blessed is the one who stays awake and remains clothed, so as not to go naked and be shamefully exposed." 16 Then they gathered the kings together to the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon.

Revelation 19:19,19 Then I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered together to wage war against the rider on the horse and his army.

C. Principal Events of the Tribulation.

1. The removal of the Church and the Restrainer of evil (2 Thes 2:1, 7, 8).

1 Thessalonians 2:1,7,8, Concerning the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ and our being gathered to him, we ask you, brothers and sisters, 7 For the secret power of lawlessness is already at work; but the one who now holds it back will continue to do so till he is taken out of the way. 8 And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will overthrow with the breath of his mouth and destroy by the splendor of his coming.

2. Restoration of the daily sacrifice in a rebuilt temple by covenant with the Antichrist (Dn 9:27).

Daniel 9:27,27 He will confirm a covenant with many for one 'seven.'[a] In the middle of the 'seven'[b] he will put an end to sacrifice and offering. And at the temple[c] he will set up an abomination that causes desolation, until the end that is decreed is poured out on him.

3. Outpouring of judgments resulting from the opening of the seven seals (Rv. 6:1, 8:1).

4. Outpouring of judgments from the sounding of the seven trumpets (Rv. 8:6 11:15)

5. The taking away of the daily sacrifice by the Antichrist, and the setting up of the abomination of desolation (Dn 9:27; 12:10,11; Mt. 24:15).

Mathew. 24:15,15 "So when you see standing in the holy place 'the abomination that causes desolation,'[a] spoken of through the prophet Daniel—let the reader understand— (This happens in the middle of the seven years, which are divided into two parts of three and one half years: Rv. 11:2,3; Dn. 9:27, 12:11; Rv. 12:14. The latter half is considered to be the "Great Tribulation.")

Rev. 12:14,14 The woman was given the two wings of a great eagle, so that she might fly to the place prepared for her in the wilderness, where she would be taken care of for a time, times and half a time, out of the serpent's reach.

6. Increased persecution of Israel (Rev 12); 144,000 Jews from the twelve tribes are sealed (Rev 7:1-8); an innumerable company of Tribulation, are taken to Heaven (Rv. 7:9-17).

7. Total control by the Beast and the False Prophet; the introduction of the mark of the Beast and his number, with compulsory worship of the Beast's image (Rev 13).

8. The judgments resulting from the outpouring of the seven vials of wrath (Rev 15, 16).

9. Judgment upon the Harlot, mystery Babylon (Rev 17, 18), who probably represents apostate religion. (After the Rapture of the true Church, organized religion with a "form of godliness but denying the power thereof" will become increasingly corrupt, even aligning herself with the Beast's government.)

10. Gathering of the kings of the East and armies of the Anti-Christ (Beast) to make war with the remnant of Israel, resulting in the battle of Armageddon (Rv. 12:17,16:2-16).

11. Celebration of the Marriage Supper of the Lamb (Rv. 19:6 9).

12. Christ returns with His armies of saints to confront the Beast and his armies, and the Beast's armies are destroyed by the brightness of Christ's Coming (Rv. 19:14-21; 2 Thes 2:8).

13. The Beast and the False Prophet are cast into the Lake of Fire (Rv. 19:20) Rv. 19:20,20 But the beast was captured, and with it the false prophet who had performed the signs on its behalf. With these signs he had deluded those who had received the mark of the beast and

worshiped its image. The two of them were thrown alive into the fiery lake of burning sulfur.

14. Satan is cast into the Bottomless Pit (the abyss) for one thousand years (Rv. 20:1-3) Rv. 20:1-3,And I saw an angel coming down out of heaven, having the key to the Abyss and holding in his hand a great chain. 2He seized the dragon, that ancient serpent, who is the devil, or Satan, and bound him for a thousand years. 3 He threw him into the Abyss, and locked and sealed it over him, to keep him from deceiving the nations anymore until the thousand years were ended. After that, he must be set free for a short time.